1.7 Contributions

Our work provides a multi-method, unified approach to studying populism and global governance. In doing so, it makes a variety of theoretical and empirical contributions. The book also carries normative implications and offers lessons for practitioners.

1.7.1 Theoretical

This book sheds light on a dimension of international organizations that is often overlooked: their ability to navigate and respond to subversive actors from within. While much of the scholarly focus on IOs has centered on their roles in addressing collective action problems—providing information, reducing transaction costs, and extending time horizons (Keohane 1984; Abbott and Snidal 1998)—these theories generally assume that IOs are coalitions of the willing. In this view, member states join because they see more benefits than costs, and when those benefits diminish, they simply exit. Alternatively, realist accounts dismiss the feasibility of cooperation altogether, offering little explanatory power for the variation in attitudes and behaviors toward IOs that we observe (Grieco 1988; Mearsheimer 1995).

Yet reality is far messier than these accounts imply. Drawing on insights from theories of domestic politics, we argue that IOs, like all institutions, are shaped by competing interests. Some of these actors seek to undermine these organizations from within, driven by ideological opposition or evolving political incentives. Members' preferences and the costs and benefits of participation are not static; they shift over time, producing friction that can lead to inefficiency, underrepresentation, and even hostility (Pratt 2021). At the international level, these dynamics are further complicated by the interplay between state representatives and their domestic constituencies, whose interests often diverge (Putnam 1988).

Existing scholarship has not fully accounted for the presence of hostile actors within IOs. Instead, the literature often assumes that member states act in good faith once they join, with poor outcomes attributed to bureaucratic overreach or isolated instances of noncompliance. These issues are thought to be correctable through internal reforms or punishment mechanisms (Barnett and Finnemore 1999; Autesserre 2014).